BIG DIFFERENCE



WHAT *AI* TELLS THE PATIENT	HOW A *DOCTOR* DIAGNOSES
Chest pain = Heart attack	Checks vitals, ECG, risk factors (age, history), then decides tests
Headache = Brain tumour	Assesses pattern, duration, triggers, neurological signs
Fatigue = Cancer	Checks sleep, stress, diet, anaemia, thyroid
Missed period = Pregnancy	Tests pregnancy, reviews cycle history, rules out hormonal causes
Weight gain = Thyroid problem	Assesses lifestyle, diet, meds, may order thyroid test if needed
Back pain = Slipped disc	Conducts a physical exam, checks posture, assesses movement
Hand tingling = Nerve damage	Checks nerve distribution, posture, circulation, may do tests
Palpitations = Heart disease	Measures pulse, anxiety, caffeine intake, advises ECG if needed
Bloating/Gas = Worms	Reviews diet, digestion patterns, rules out common GI causes
Hair fall = Hormonal disorder	Looks at nutrition, stress, scalp health, then considers tests
Joint pain = Arthritis	Examines joint, checks inflammation, history, movement
Skin rash = Allergy/infection	Does visual exam, checks history, exposure, prescribes simple meds

deadlines, telling friends she finally knew "what is wrong" with her. By the time she sought help, she had begun performing the diagnosis as much as believing it. What she did not know is that a psychiatric assessment does not rely on a checklist alone. Clinicians look at childhood history, persistence across settings, anxiety, depression, sleep quality, and whether symptoms impair life consistently or only during difficult periods. In her case, clinicians found severe anxiety, poor sleep and exam stress, not ADHD.

The trouble with patients landing up after AI has convinced them that their symptoms match the worst possible disease is that it begins to tell not just on the individual but on the entire healthcare system. Anxiety sends these low-risk patients to overwhelm emergency rooms, clogging up triage desks, waiting areas and taking up the precious time of hospital staff, delaying care for people who are really sick. Unnecessary tests are another outcome. "Patients frequently request advanced investigations like MRI scans, even when clinical evaluation may not immediately indicate the need. This shift adds pressure on healthcare systems and can lead to unnecessary testing," says Dr Sharma.

HOW TO BREAK THE CYCLE

In a time of instant gratification, AI is a convenient tool to relieve anxiety. It can produce a convincing answer in seconds, along with treatment suggestions. A few quick taps, and you can have lists of "best tests for chest pain", a dosage schedule for over-the-counter medicines, and recommendations such as an MRI scan for headaches. Chatbots can make the answers seem personal and customised, except that explanations are only as good as the information fed into them. They cannot, for example, examine a swollen knee or notice pallor. They cannot assess what a patient may have left out because they did not know it was relevant.

Educated, capable people are not immune to cyberchondria either. This is because such behaviour is driven